

Grade inflation

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Grade Inflation

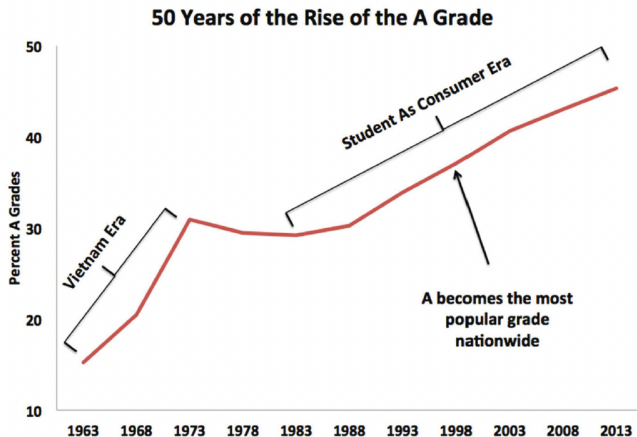
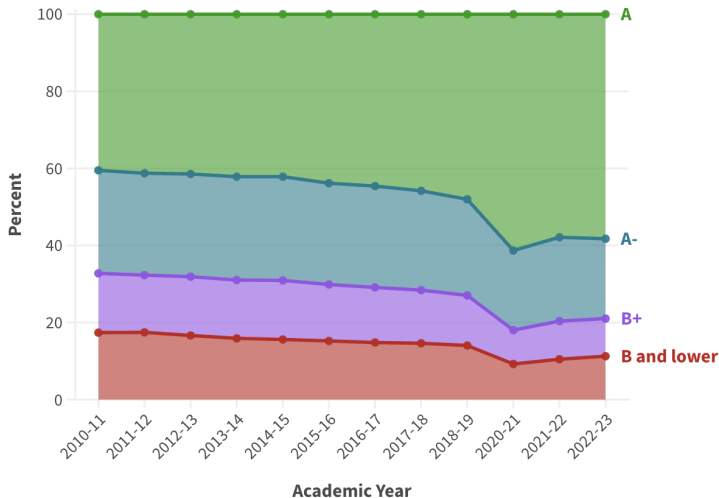


Figure 3. Grade inflation in the United States (from gradeinflation.com).

from gradeinflation.com

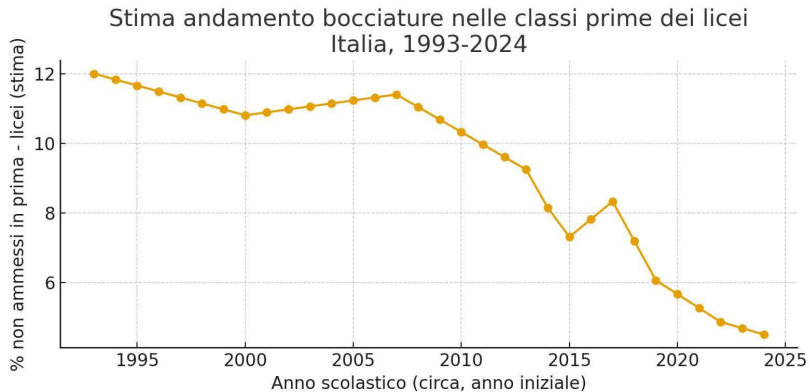
Grade Inflation

Yale College letter-grade distribution (2010-2023)



Data are disaggregated from Table 1 of the “Grade Report Update: 2022-2023,” courtesy of Ray Fair. To calculate the percentage of A-’s, the News subtracted the percentage of “A’s Only” from the percentage of “A’s and A-’s.” To calculate the percentage of B+’s, the News subtracted the percentage of “A’s and A-’s” and the percentage of “B’s and lower” from 100. The academic year 2019-20 is not included here or in Table 1 because grades were mostly pass/fail.

Grade Inflation in the secondary school (Italy)



Do students' professors evaluation predict their learning?

Braga and colleagues (2014) found that students' evaluations negatively predict their performance in future classes

Table 8
Teacher effectiveness and students' evaluations.

	Teaching quality		Lecturing clarity		Teacher ability in generating interest		Course logistics		Course workload	
	[1]	[2]	[3]	[4]	[5]	[6]	[7]	[8]	[9]	[10]
Teacher effectiveness										
Benchmark	-0.496** (0.236)	-	-0.249** (0.113)	-	-0.552** (0.226)	-	-0.124 (0.095)	-	-0.090 (0.104)	-
Contemporaneous	-	0.238*** (0.055)	-	0.116*** (0.029)	-	0.214*** (0.044)	-	0.078*** (0.019)	-	-0.007 (0.025)

*"In order to rationalize our findings it is useful to think of good teachers – i.e. those who provide their students with knowledge that is useful in future learning – as teachers who require effort from their students. **Students dislike exerting effort** [emphasis mine] "*

What kind of incentive do SET provide?

Surprise...surprise



Lionel Page
@page_eco

...

The empirical evidence seems quite clear that student evaluations of teaching (SET) mechanically lead to grade inflation and lowering of standards.

[sciencedirect.com/science/article/...](https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/...)

Traduci con DeepL

Traduci post

The overall implication is that students, administrators and faculty are engaged in an individually rational but arguably socially destructive game. Administrators want higher SETs because it leads to higher grades and higher student retention rates, which means more tuition and tax revenues. Faculty want higher teaching evaluations because it leads to higher salaries, and students want higher grades for the same reason. But the overall social effect is to make both the SET a faulty signal of teaching quality and grades a faulty signal of future performance on the job. No student, no individual faculty member, no individual college or university administrator, and no college or university institution have much of an incentive to break this vicious cycle.



Doug Campbell
@TradeandMoney · 2 nov 2025

Each year I hire a professor early on, used to get bad reviews occasionally

Inflate and be happy :-)

Management by results: Student evaluation of faculty teaching and the mis-measurement of performance

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Abstract

Using data on 4 years of courses at American University, regression results show that actual grades have a significant, positive effect on student evaluations of teaching (SETs), controlling for expected grade and fixed effects for both faculty and courses, and for possible endogeneity. Implications are that the SET is a faulty measure of teaching quality and grades a faulty signal of future job performance. Students, faculty, and provost appear to be engaged in an individually rational but socially destructive game of grade inflation centered on the link between SETs and grades. When performance is hard to measure, pay-for-performance, embodied by the link between SETs and faculty pay, may have unintended adverse consequences.

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...but at what cost?

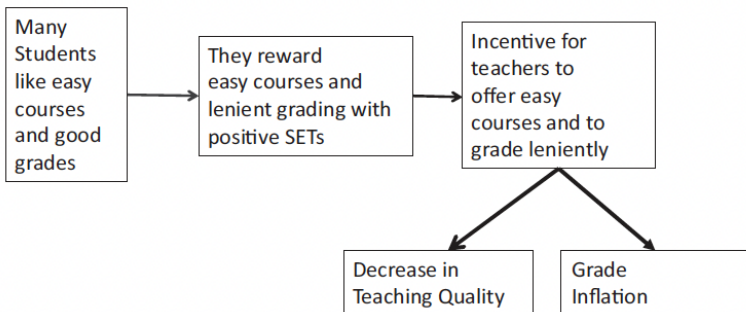


Figure 2. The biasing effect of SETs on teaching quality and grades: A process model.

Stroebe (2020). "Student Evaluations of Teaching Encourages Poor Teaching and Contributes to Grade Inflation: A Theoretical and Empirical Analysis". *Basic and Applied Social Psychology*.

...but at what cost?

“We find that, conditional on a large set of individuals’ observable characteristics—including geographical origin, high school grades, and socioeconomic background—**graduates from high-grading departments tend to perform significantly worse in the labour market.** Moreover, graduates from high-grading universities are **less likely to succeed in external qualifying exams that are required for many professional activities.** These results suggest that the significant variations in grades observed in Italy across disciplines and universities reflect, to a large extent, differences in grading standards.”

1/3 Bagues, Sylos Labini, Zinovyeva, (2008). “Differential grading standards and university funding: Evidence from Italy”. *CESifo Economic Studies*

...but at what cost?

“In line with this evidence, we also find that the output measure of university quality adopted by the Italian Ministry of Education to allocate funds across universities—namely, **the number of full-time equivalent students (FTE), defined as the ratio between the number of exams that students passed and the total number of exams they should have taken—is negatively correlated with graduates’ labour-market outcomes.**”

2/3 Bagues, Sylos Labini, Zinovyeva, (2008). “Differential grading standards and university funding: Evidence from Italy”. *CESifo Economic Studies*

...and what could be done?

This finding raises concerns about the effectiveness of such funding mechanisms. In light of this evidence, the **implementation of quality-assurance mechanisms—such as a system of external examiners**, as in the UK—**should be seriously considered** as a necessary complement to any output-based funding scheme. “
3/3 Bagues, Sylos Labini, Zinovyeva, (2008).”Differential grading standards and university funding: Evidence from Italy”. *CESifo Economic Studies*

What is the real outcome in education?

*“Grade inflation is another practice that serves the convenience of the professors rather than the interests of the students. While those students who do not wish to study hard may enjoy grade inflation, it has been found that students who take lower-level courses from professors who give easy grades do not do as well in upper-level courses as students who took their preparatory courses from professors with stricter grading standards. **In short, the long-run interests of students as a whole are sacrificed by grade inflation.**”*

1/2 Thomas Sowell (2011). *Economic facts and fallacies*. Basic Books.

What is the real outcome in education?



However, grade inflation makes life easier for professors who need not face time-consuming complaints from students about low or failing grades nor put up with the unpleasantness that can accompany such complaints. Moreover, the unpopularity of professors who give low grades can also be reflected in negative student evaluations at the end of a course, which in turn can negatively affect career advancement, especially for young faculty who have not yet achieved tenure."

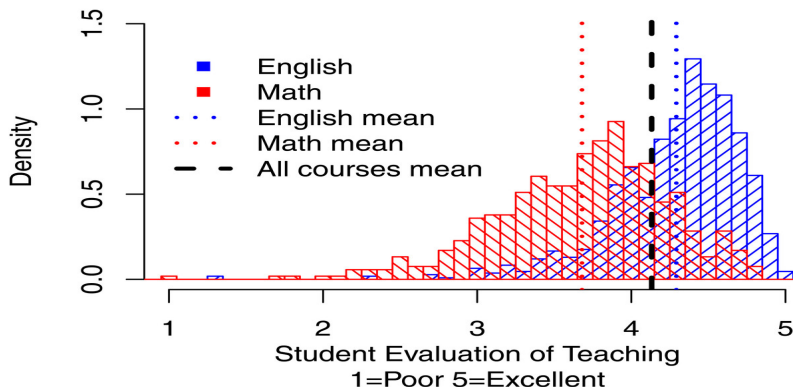
2/2. Thomas Sowell (2011). *Economic facts and fallacies*. Basic Books.

...but there is some hope

Table 2
Percent A's and A-'s by Subject, 2022-2023

Enrollment greater than 500	
Percent	
52.39	Economics
55.18	Mathematics
55.82	Psychology (17.32% CR)
62.07	Chemistry
63.49	Molecular Biophysics & Biochemistry
65.43	Philosophy (14.62% CR)
66.17	Molecular, Cellular & Dev Biol
66.96	Physics
67.94	Astronomy
68.27	Statistics and Data Science
70.82	Computer Science
72.27	Biology
72.44	American Studies
73.41	Environmental Studies
73.66	Earth and Planetary Sciences
74.02	Political Science
74.40	Engineering #5
74.44	Anthropology
77.11	Global Affairs
79.63	History
79.71	Linguistics
80.04	Directed Studies
80.79	English
81.60	Humanities
82.21	African American Studies
82.71	Regional Studies #8
85.43	Ethnicity, Race, & Migration

And finally, a sort of a COI statement



from Uttl & Smiber, 2017. "Student evaluations of teaching: teaching quantitative courses can be hazardous to one's career."

PeerJ

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